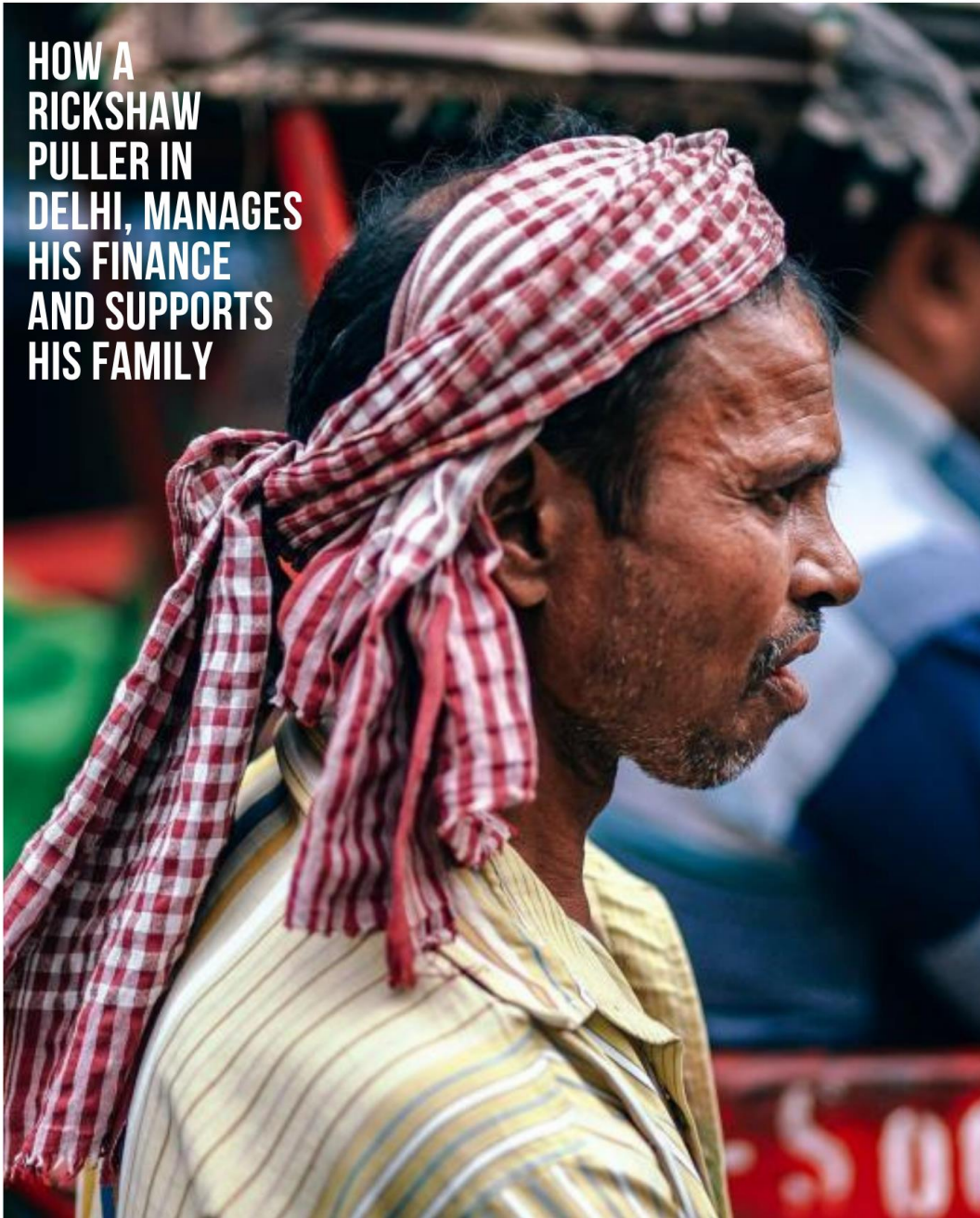


RESEARCH PAPER

FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT OF RICKSHAW PULLERS IN DELHI

**HOW A
RICKSHAW
PULLER IN
DELHI, MANAGES
HIS FINANCE
AND SUPPORTS
HIS FAMILY**



Research Paper
Financial Management of Rickshaw Puller in Delhi

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ABSTRACT

This research is an attempt to find out how they manage their finances and supports its family. The study is based on primary data of 50 rickshaw pullers collected through the field survey and direct questionnaire to the rickshaw pullers in 2 places in Delhi (Jama Masjid, Sadar Bazaar). The survey was carried out during the months of February and March 2022. The rickshaw pullers work under extremely hard conditions to earn daily wages and the overall analysis of the study also reveals that the rickshaw pullers are one of the poorest sections of the society, living in abject poverty but playing a pivotal role in the intra-city transportation system. Neither their working environment regulated nor their social security issues are addressed. They are also unaware of the governmental schemes launched for poverty alleviation and their accessibility to basic amenities and infrastructural facilities is also very poor.

INTRODUCTION

The rickshaw originates from the Japanese word jinrikisha (人力車, 人 jin = human, 力 riki = power or force, 車 sha = vehicle), which literally means "human-powered vehicle" and have been invented in Japan in the 1860s, at the beginning of a rapid period of technical advancement. In the 19th century, rickshaw pulling became an inexpensive, popular mode of transportation across Asia. Peasants who migrated to large Asian cities often worked first as a rickshaw runner. It was "the deadliest occupation in the East and the most degrading for human beings to pursue."

The rickshaw's popularity in Japan declined by the 1930s with the advent of automated forms of transportation, like automobiles and trains. In China, the rickshaw's popularity began to decline in the 1920s. In Singapore, the rickshaw's popularity increased into the 20th century. There were approximately 50,000 rickshaws in 1920 and that number doubled by 1930.

Around 1880, rickshaws appeared in India, first in Shimla and at the end of the century, it was introduced in Kolkata. Until the 1980s plying rickshaws were found mainly in the walled or old cities of the country, middle-class neighbourhoods and in the outlying colonies of cities. Now one can see them plying in virtually all elite colonies of big cities of the country.

Now, in India, about 0.86 million people are engaged in pulling cycle rickshaws as an occupation. This non-polluting and environment-friendly cycle rickshaw is one of the cheapest modes of intra-city transport, plays a pivotal role in providing point-to-point connectivity, helping people reach nearby markets, railway stations, and bus terminals, and allowing them to commute short distances in narrow lanes where cars and auto-rickshaws cannot easily travel. The neighbourhood rickshaw puller often provides door-to-door transport services for children in nursery schools. In crowded markets, they serve as a convenient mode of transport in ferrying goods to nearby areas. Rickshaws are also used for garbage collection. Lately, cycle rickshaws have become an indispensable feeder service for the Metro and bus stations and can be found queued up outside many Metro stations in Delhi. For hundreds of homeless rickshaw pullers, by night their cycle rickshaws get transformed into makeshift beds.

Cycle rickshaws were introduced into Delhi in the 1940s when they were seen as a major technological advancement over the hand-pulled rickshaws. One would have expected them to disappear with the fast growth of modern, motorised transport. But their number has grown phenomenally in the last couple of decades, testifying to a vibrant and increasing demand for this service. Mr Parreira, the Commissioner of Traffic police, says there are about ten lakh rickshaws in the entire region of Delhi. More conservative estimates put the

figure at six lakhs. In addition, there are at least 20,000 mechanics servicing this sector. Delhi has several thousand contractors owning anything from five or ten to a few hundred rickshaws. Add to it thousands of those in the small scale sector who are involved in the manufacture of various components used in the assembling rickshaws. On average, the earnings of a rickshaw puller support five or six others. Thus, at least 50 to 60 lakh people's livelihood is dependent on the labour of Delhi's rickshaw pullers.

AIM AND OBJECTIVES

This research paper focuses on the financial management by the urban rickshaw pullers of Delhi using the quantitative method. The main aim of the study is to highlight the primary earnings of a rickshaw puller, the costs related to his vocations, savings if any and if there are shortfalls.

The objective of the study is to answer the following research questions:

1. What does the earning of a rickshaw puller look like?
2. What does an average expenditure of a rickshaw puller look like?
3. How does a rickshaw puller manage shortfalls?
4. What is the basic saving structure of a rickshaw puller look like?

Later in the study, a few recommendations have been provided according to the study for the economy of the country.

STUDY AREA

2 places in Old Delhi had been chosen as the study area for the research work which are:

1. Jama Masjid- is one of the largest mosques in India and it is located within the historic city of Shahjahanabad, today known as the locality of Old Delhi.
2. Sadar Bazaar- is the largest wholesale cosmetics jewellery market of household items in Old Delhi. It is located on the western side of Kharbi Baoli street

DATA AND METHODOLOGY

The study is based on the primary data generated through the field survey and direct questionnaire to the respondents in Jama Masjid and Sadar Bazaar. The survey was carried out during the month of February and March 2022. Firstly, 50 rickshaw pullers were interviewed for the collection of some personal information, their socio-economic characteristics, causes of rickshaw pulling, their earnings, the costs related to vocations, savings if any and if there are shortfalls. After the fieldwork was over, the data collected by individual interviews were scrutinized and processed in tabular forms according to the requirements of the various facets of the study.

ANALYSIS OF RICKSHAW PULLERS

TABLE 1: Age Structure of Rickshaw Pullers Population

AGE GROUPS	PERCENT
19-30	34
31-40	26
41-50	22
51-60	12
Above 60	6
TOTAL	100

Table 1 shows the age structure of rickshaw pullers in Jama Masjid and Sadar Bazaar. Rickshaw pulling is an arduous nature of job which requires hard labour and physical strength in which age plays a vital role. The highest proportion of rickshaw pullers, 36 per cent has been recorded in the 19- 30 age group, it is only because they are young and energetic in this age group. After 30 years of age, the data given in Table 1 shows the declining trend in the proportion of rickshaw pullers in various age groups. The proportion has been recorded at 26 per cent in the 31-40 age group, 22 per cent in the 41-50 age group, 12 percent in 51-60 and only 6 percent in above 60 years of age. On the basis of the above analysis of the data given in Table 1, it may be inferred that the community of cycle rickshaw pullers is dominated by the persons in young and productive age groups and have a very little share in the juvenile and senile age groups. All rickshaw pullers were males because no female was found to be engaged in the cycle rickshaw pulling.

TABLE 2: Marital Status of Rickshaw Pullers

STATUS	PERCENT
Married	78
Unmarried	14
Widower	8
TOTAL	100

Table 2 provides information about the marital status of rickshaw pullers. An examination of Table 2 indicates that 78 per cent of the rickshaw pullers are married whereas 14 per cent are unmarried and the remaining 8 per cent are widowers.

TABLE 3: Educational Status of Rickshaw Pullers

EDUCATIONAL STATUS	NO. OF RICKSHAW PULLERS
Illiterate	59
10 th	21
12 th	18
Graduate	2
TOTAL	100

Table 3 presents the distribution of the educational status of rickshaw pullers. The analysis of Table 3 shows that, out of 50 rickshaw pullers, 59 percent are illiterate and only 41 per cent are literate. Out of 41 per cent literates, 21 per cent got education upto 10th, 18 per cent upto 12th and only 02 per cent up to graduation.

TABLE 4: Origin of Rickshaw Pullers

STATE/DISTRICT	PERCENT
Delhi	12
Bihar	36
Uttar Pradesh	18
Madhya Pradesh	14
Odisha	8
West Bengal	8
Others	4
TOTAL	100

Table 4 shows the origin of the rickshaw pullers. It can be seen in Table 4 that the majority of the rickshaw pullers (36 per cent) have their origin from Bihar and had migrated to Delhi and 12 per cent have their origin in Delhi. The migration of rickshaw pullers from UP has been recorded at 18 per cent, 14 per cent, 8 per cent, 8 per cent from Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and West Bengal respectively.

TABLE 5: Percentage Distribution of Socio-Economic Causes of Rickshaw Pulling

CAUSES	NO. OF RICKSHAW PULLERS
Unemployment	24
Poverty	18
Illiteracy	16
Unskilled	10
Low income	10
Migration	10
Large size of family	6
Debt and uncertainty in production of crops	4
Small size of land holding	2
Total	100

Table 5 provides data about the socio-economic causes which compelled the poor people to engage themselves in rickshaw pulling. Unemployment, poverty, low income and small size of land holdings are the major economic causes that forced about 54 per cent of the rickshaw pullers to involve themselves in the rickshaw pulling, whereas among the social factors, large family size, illiteracy, migration pushed to 32 per cent of them to pull rickshaws. Moreover, unskillness and debt and uncertainty in the production of crops derived 14 per cent of the rickshaw pullers the pulling of the rickshaws.

RESEARCH QUESTION 1:

How does the earning of a rickshaw puller look like?

A rickshaw puller works under extremely hard conditions to earn daily wages. These low-wage earners have to spend at least eight to ten hours in their vocation, whether under the blinding sun, during freezing winters or on watery days. For short distances and highly congested lanes, it is the preferable mode of transportation in Delhi. This physically demanding job has a low rate of carrying passengers, mostly because it is non-motorized. Another reason can be its simplicity and non – attractiveness. Rickshaws do not offer any lucrative service features; their only purpose is to transport the passengers. Further, it is a slow-moving mode of transportation.

Now, assuming that the rickshaw puller is physically fit, the factors that could affect his earnings are weather conditions, age of the rickshaw puller, traffic, road conditions, and many more. This means the earnings of a rickshaw puller are not stable. There is no steadiness in their daily wages and it's of low value. Apart from transporting passengers, rickshaw pullers also load consignments. Factors affecting the fare of pulling consignments are similar to pulling passengers plus the weight of the load. This too indicates the earning of a rickshaw puller is unsteady.

TABLE 6: Rates charged for rides by rickshaw pullers

Rates for Distance Covered	Average	Minimum	Maximum
For Short Distance	₹10	₹10	₹20
For Medium Distance	₹25	₹20	₹30
For Long Distance	₹35	₹30	₹40

Table 6 shows the varying rates charged by the rickshaw pullers per ride depending upon the distance. Other factors that contributed to determining the rate are the bargaining power of the passengers, pullers' assertiveness in demanding a rate, and weather and road conditions.

TABLE 7: Percentage Distribution of the number of customers of Rickshaw Pullers

NO. OF CUSTOMERS (IN RUPEES)	PERCENT
5-10	16
10-15	20
15-20	46

20-25	18
TOTAL	100

Table 7 shows the number of customers the rickshaw pullers have in a day. 46 per cent rickshaw pullers have the customers' upto 15 to 20. The average number of customers is 16 (approx.)

TABLE 8: Percentage Distribution of Average Daily Income of Rickshaw Pullers

DAILY INCOME (IN RUPEES)	PERCENT
50-100	16
100-150	18
150-200	38
200-250	16
250-300	12
TOTAL	100

Table 8 presents the percentage distribution of average daily income earned by rickshaw pullers in rickshaw pulling in Jama Masjid and Sadar Bazaar. An analysis of data given in Table 8 shows that 38 per cent of rickshaw pullers earned rupees 150-200 per day, 18 per cent gained between 100-150 rupees in a day and 16 per cent could get less than rupees 100 in a day. Moreover, the average daily income [Rs.170 (by calculating mean by Simple method)] of 38 per cent rickshaw pullers has been recorded between rupees 150-200 and only 12 per cent managed to earn more than rupees 250 in a day.

TABLE 9: Percentage Distribution of Average Daily Working Hours and Average Monthly Working Days of Rickshaw Pullers

DAILY WORKING HOURS	PERCENT
Less than 6	14
6-8	18
8-10	30
More than 10	38

TOTAL	100
MONTHLY WORKING DAYS	PERCENT
Less than 15	8
15-20	18
20-25	34
More than 25	40
TOTAL	100

Table 9 shows that 38 per cent of rickshaw pullers do the arduous work of rickshaw pulling for more than 10 hours in a day and 30 per cent ply their rickshaws between 8 to 10 hours in a day. Moreover, the average daily working hours of 18 per cent of rickshaw pullers have been reported between 6 to 8 hours and 14 per cent less than 6 hours.

The further analysis of data provided in Table 9 shows that the average monthly working days of 40 per cent of rickshaw pullers are more than 25 days and 34 per cent were found to be engaged in rickshaw pulling between 20 to 25 days in a month. However, 8 per cent of rickshaw pullers reported pulling the rickshaws on roads for less than 15 days in a month.

Therefore, the range of minimum and maximum earnings showed a wide gap – for instance, minimum earnings were reportedly Rs.50 while maximum reported earnings stood at Rs.300. One factor responsible for this variation in was that the earnings differed by age of pullers and the time each rickshaw puller devote to pulling.

On average, the estimated gross earnings of rickshaw pullers, for short, medium, and long-distance were Rs. 160, Rs. 400 and Rs.560 respectively. However, since the number of rides undertaken by a rickshaw puller covers short, medium, and long distances in general on any day, the study computed an average of these figures. Therefore, **on average, the estimated daily earnings on a normal day stood at Rs.373.**

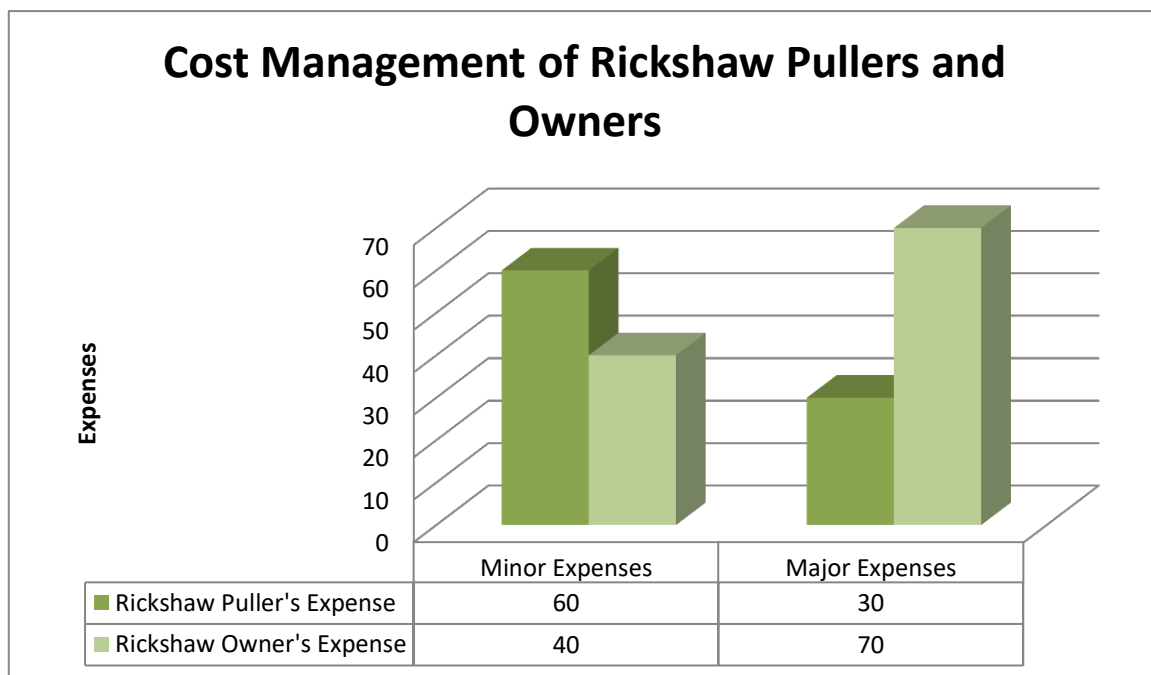
RESEARCH QUESTION 2:

How does an average expenditure of a rickshaw puller look like?

Rickshaw pullers face both direct costs and indirect costs.

Direct Costs-

Certain work-related costs are incurred for the maintenance of rickshaws. These costs are to be undertaken by the cedars or owners of rickshaws. The rickshaws are being driven by any minor breakdown (e.g., tire puncture) the costs of repairing are normally paid by the rickshaw puller and may or may not be reimbursed by the owner.



The figure above shows the responses of the sampled respondents about the costs borne by them for minor repairs and major repairs.

60 per cent of rickshaw pullers in the sample stated that more often they bear the incurred on minor repairs. However, the owner would bear the costs. 40 per cent of rickshaw pullers reported that rickshaw owner spends on minor repairs.

In the eventuality of a fine or penalty levied by the MCD, a large percentage (70%) of sample respondents acknowledged that the rickshaw owners bear these costs. However, 30 per cent of rickshaw pullers expressed that they bear these costs (especially, traffic violations).

Indirect Costs-

There are certain indirect (non-financial) costs that the rickshaw pullers are forced to pay and which have a monetary implication for the pullers. There is either loss of work for a few productive hours of the day or there is a temporary loss of work (up to two weeks) and consequently, they are incapable of earning due to factors beyond their control.

Expenses of Rickshaw Pullers

An important characteristic of the urban poor is that they are dependent on their ability to earn cash incomes daily, which helps them to buy most of their food and other necessities.

Consumption expenditures relate to the total expenditures of sample respondents spent on consumption needs in their daily life. These broadly are expenditures on food, housing (rent), toiletries (soap and toothpaste), cooking fuel, health care, durable goods (Television, radio, cooker, etc.) and bad habit (smoking, gutka and tobacco, drinking, gambling, drugs).

TABLE 10: Percentage Distribution of Daily Expense on food of Rickshaw Pullers

AMOUNT SPEND	PERCENT
160-170	8
170-180	68
180-190	12
190-200	12
TOTAL	100

Table 10 shows the percentage distribution of daily expense on food. Majorly, the amount spend on food daily is between Rs. 170 to Rs. 180. Average amount spend on food is Rs. 177.8 which is 45.76 per cent of the total earnings.

TABLE 11: Percentage Distribution of Daily Expense on housing (rent) of Rickshaw Pullers

AMOUNT SPEND	PERCENT
0	12
20-40	72
40-60	16
TOTAL	100

Table 11 shows the percentage distribution of daily expenses on housing (rent). Majorly, the amount spent on rent daily is between Rs. 20 to Rs. 40 (monthly rent divided into days). 12 per cent of rickshaw pullers said that they had no expenses for rent, suggesting that they were homeless, and living either on the streets or in public spaces. The average amount spend on rent is Rs. 30.8 which is 8.25 per cent of the total earnings.

TABLE 12: Percentage Distribution of Daily Expense on toiletries of Rickshaw Pullers

AMOUNT SPEND	PERCENT
0-10	86
10-20	12
20-30	2
TOTAL	100

Table 12 shows the percentage distribution of daily expense on toiletries (soap and toothpaste). Majorly, the amount spend on toiletries daily is upto Rs. 10. Average amount spend on food is Rs. 6.6 which is 1.76 per cent of the total earnings.

TABLE 13: Percentage Distribution of Daily Expense on cooking fuel of Rickshaw Pullers

AMOUNT SPEND	PERCENT
10-20	36
20-30	56
30-40	8
TOTAL	100

Table 13 shows the percentage distribution of daily expense on cooking fuel. Majorly, the amount spend on fuel daily is between Rs. 20 to Rs. 30. Average amount spend on fuel is Rs. 22.2 which is 5.95 per cent of the total earnings.

TABLE 14: Percentage Distribution of Daily Expense on bad habits of Rickshaw Pullers

AMOUNT SPEND	PERCENT
10-20	44
20-30	52

30-40	4
TOTAL	100

Table 14 shows the percentage distribution of daily expense on bad habits (smoking, gutka and tobacco, drinking, gambling, drugs). Majorly, the amount spend on fuel daily is between Rs. 20 to Rs. 30. Average amount spend on fuel is Rs. 21 which is 5.63 per cent of the total earnings.

TABLE 15: Average percentage spend on expenditure by rickshaw pullers

EXPENDITURES	PERCENT SPEND (AVERAGE)
Food	45.76
Housing (Rent)	8.25
Toiletries	1.76
Cooking Fuel	5.95
Bad habits	5.63
TOTAL	67.35

Table 15 shows the average per cent spend on the expenses incurred on necessities by rickshaw pullers. The total of 67.35 percent of the total income is spent on the expenses.

RESEARCH QUESTION 3:

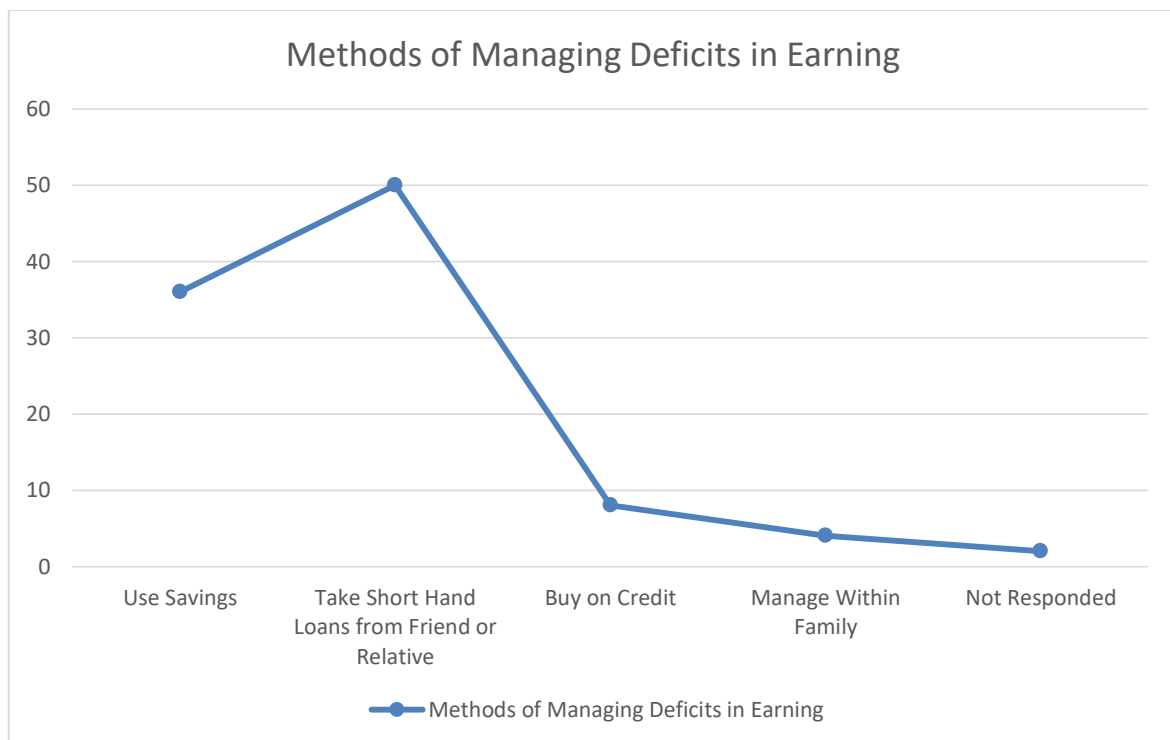
How does a rickshaw puller manage shortfalls?

A rickshaw puller's earning is variable and it depends heavily on a day's work. It might be possible, due to certain reasons a puller is not able to go about his work or doesn't earn an average income a day.

So, how does a rickshaw puller manage this shortfall?

TABLE 16: Methods of managing deficits in earning

	METHODS OF MANAGING DEFICITS IN EARNING
Use Savings	36
Take short hand loans from friend or relative	50
Buy on credit	8
Manage within family	4
Not responded	2
TOTAL	100



As per the Graph, Given Above, it is shown that 36 per cent of the Samples said that they manage their shortfalls by their Savings, 50 per cent said that they take Loans from either their families or friends, 8 per cent said that they start buying groceries and other things on credit, 4 per cent said that they manage within the family as their other family members are working, and 2 per cent didn't disclose their data.

Since many of these expenses are essential, rickshaw pullers must carefully manage their funds to be able to save. The interviewed pullers had several strategies for managing their expenses when their earnings were particularly low.

CASE STUDY



Mr. Mehboob Alam, explained that he has fallen into the debt trap by asking for Loans to repay his other loans, now working extra hours for his family and to repay the loans

RESEARCH QUESTION 4:**What is the basic saving structure of a rickshaw puller look like?**

Saving is essentially practised in cash or kind. An important strategy adopted by the poor is to manage their money better by holding on to what they have avoiding needless expenditures and finding a safe place to store whatever they have. This will also help them in investing.

TABLE 17: Savings

Savings	N	%
Do you put away some portion of your daily earnings as savings?		
YES	74	74%
NO	26	26%
If YES, then how often?		
Daily	46	46%
Weekly	6	6%
Monthly	3	3%
As when surplus is available	45	45%
Where do you keep your savings?		
1. Keep savings with Self	54	54%
2. Keep Savings with Shopkeepers	28	28%
3. Keep Savings with Spouse	3	3%
4. Keep Savings with Rickshaw Owners	2	2%
5. Keep Savings with Relative	2	2%
6. Keep Savings at the place of Stay	2	2%
7. Keep Money Buried	2	2%
8. Remit Home Regularly	1	1%
9. Deposit in Bank Account	1	1%
10. No Response	2	2%
11. No Surplus to Save	1	1%
12. Give a Loan to a fellow puller	1	1%

According to the table17, where N = 50, the rickshaw pullers stated the following:

1. Do you put away some portion of your daily earnings as savings?

Here 74% of the rickshaw pullers said Yes and 26% said No.

2. If YES, then how often?

46% of the rickshaw pullers save daily, 6% save weekly, 3% monthly, and 45% when surplus is available.

3. Where do you keep your savings?

54% of the rickshaw pullers keep their savings with self, 28% with shopkeepers, 3% with spouses, 2% with rickshaw owners, 2% with relatives, 2% at the place of stay, 1% buried, 1% remit home regularly, 2% deposit in a bank account, 1% of the rickshaw pullers have no response, 1% have no surplus to save, 1% give a loan to a fellow puller.

CASE STUDY



Mr. Badal Singh, while discussing the hardships of the Savings and how he saves his money with a relative in his hometown – Bihar

CONCLUSION

- Earnings of urban rickshaw pullers are unstable and unpredictable.
- Earnings depend on the road conditions, weather conditions, bargaining power of the passengers and the puller, and age of the puller, among the other factors.
- Analysis of the rickshaw pullers states:
 1. The community of cycle rickshaw pullers is dominated by persons in young and productive age groups and has a very little share in the juvenile and senile age groups. All rickshaw pullers were males because no female was found to be engaged in the cycle rickshaw pulling.
 2. 78 per cent of the rickshaw pullers are married whereas 14 per cent are unmarried and the remaining 8 per cent are widowers. However, most of the married rickshaw pullers reported that they migrated alone from rural areas in the city in search of jobs and their wives are still staying in rural areas.
 3. Out of 50 rickshaw pullers, 59 per cent are illiterate and only 41 per cent are literate. Out of 41 per cent literates, 21 per cent got education upto 10th, 18 percent upto 12th and only 02 per cent up to graduation. Therefore, due to their illiteracy and unskillness, the poverty-stricken persons do not have any other alternative to earn the means of livelihood but to get easily engaged in rickshaw pulling.
 4. The majority of the rickshaw pullers (36 per cent) have their origin from Bihar and had migrated to Delhi and 12 per cent have their origin in Delhi.
 5. Unemployment, poverty, low income and small size of landholdings are the major economic causes that forced about 54 per cent of the rickshaw pullers to involve themselves in the rickshaw pulling, whereas among the social factors, large family size, illiteracy, migration pushed to 32 per cent of them to pull rickshaws. Moreover, unskillness and debt and uncertainty in the production of crops derived 14 per cent of the rickshaw pullers the pulling the rickshaws.
- On average, **the estimated daily earnings of the rickshaw pullers on a normal day stood at Rs.373.**
- Consumption expenditures relate to the total expenditures of sample respondents spent on consumption needs in their daily life. These broadly are expenditures on food (**45.76 %**), housing (rent) (**8.25%**), toiletries (soap and toothpaste) (**1.76%**), cooking fuel (**5.95%**), and bad habits (smoking, gutka and tobacco, drinking, gambling, drugs) (**5.63%**). **A total of 67.35 per cent of the total income is spent on expenses.**
- In times of shortfall of money, it was studied that 50 per cent of pullers borrow money from their kith and kins while 36 per cent spent it from their retained earnings.
- Rickshaw pullers find it difficult to save money not only because of budget constraints but also because it is difficult to find a place where money is safe.
- Moreover, rickshaw pullers are facing threats. Uber, Ola, and E-rickshaws have eaten into their market share.
- Market regulation does not make it easy to buy or sell rickshaws. Also, annual renewals are a pain.
- Since it's not safe to ride an auto (no seat belts for the driver and the passenger), new users are not coming to it

RECOMMENDATIONS

The study on the money management behaviour of cycle rickshaw pullers has important implications for the banking and microfinance sectors regarding how to design, market, and deliver products that appeal to low-income users and are also viable for the financial institutions. These products are essential for the financial inclusion of this segment of the urban poor. The most significant insight is that rickshaw pullers are potentially bankable; the banking sector may be able to mobilize savings and remittances from rickshaw pullers by offering migrant-friendly products. Such products would make the best use of the features of the informal saving methods popular among this urban poor group and improve upon the informal mechanisms' negative aspects.

There is profit at the bottom of the pyramid. It is the right time to get the business models and innovative products that fit the different segments of urban poor migrants. The banking sector should target the urban poor as customers, not as beneficiaries, as suggested by C.K. Prahalad in his popular work *"Fortune at the Bottom of the Pyramid."*

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